

Episode 28: Special Episode – Theatrical *CLANNAD* Release Commemoration – Stories with Director Dezaki

Well then.

I first saw Director Dezaki (出崎) live during the character colour checking for theatrical *Air*. That day, he came into the colour design room at Toei Animation Oizumi (大泉) Studio with directors, character designers, animation directors and others. The exceptionally tall director appeared casually. "Ah! Director Dezaki!" I thought. He passed in front of my seat near the entrance and went to the back. I wasn't participating in theatrical *Air* (Tsukada-san (塚田) from *One Piece* handled it), and at that moment I was having character colour meetings for *Saint Seiya: Hades Sanctuary Chapter* (聖闘士星矢ハーデス冥界編) with Director Katsumata (勝間田) at my desk.

I can be honest now - I was jealous of Tsukada-san (laughs). I mean, she was working on that Director Dezaki's project at Toei Animation. This kind of thing probably won't happen again (bitter laugh). I heard it was a difficult project with various troubles, but man, I wanted to do theatrical *Air*. I was carrying multiple projects including *Saint Seiya* so it was impossible from the start. As long as I work at Toei Animation, ah, I probably can't work with Director Dezaki, I thought.

Then came theatrical *CLANNAD*! Director Dezaki again!

Man, I was shocked. I almost immediately raised my hand saying "Yes!" But as usual I was overloaded with work and couldn't easily volunteer. I think this was around last year at this time. A feature-length theatrical work can't be easily handled alongside other projects. Actually around then *CLANNAD* storyboards were starting to come up and overall meetings had already been held twice. We couldn't continue meetings without a colour designer any longer, so after various discussions, it was decided "Well, somehow with Tsujita..." and I gloriously joined the *CLANNAD* team.

I hadn't told staff much, but I'd actually been a longtime fan of Director Dezaki's works.

My first encounter was in high school. I was completely captivated by *Ashita no Joe 2* (あしたのジョー2). This was an era without DVDs. When our house didn't even have a VCR yet. During the original broadcast and later reruns, I was a high schooler glued to the TV (laughs). Ever since, I'd been continuously captivated by Director Dezaki's works - *Ace wo Nerae! 2*, *Ace wo Nerae Final Stage*, *Black Jack*, and countless others.

So, *CLANNAD* overall meetings.

Based on storyboards Director Dezaki created, main staff including producer, directors, character designers, art designers, animation directors, art directors, colour designers, etc. participated in meetings held roughly every 10 days to 2 weeks. About 100-150 cuts discussed per meeting. The director would explain storyboard content, and all main staff would confirm necessary setting orders and content agreements.

I finally joined at the third meeting. According to my notes, it was October 7th. The director arrived about 15 minutes late as usual with a casual entrance. In the meeting room, all main staff sat around the director. I happened to be directly facing the director. Brief self-introduction. A bit nervous (laughs). "Oh, please take care of me," said the director. This became our first conversation (?).

The meeting began. Just reading through storyboards made my heart race. I knew nothing about *CLANNAD* as a work, read the given scenario, but naturally couldn't complete the game (bitter laugh). So actually, *CLANNAD* was built in my mind from given source materials, the scenario, and the director's storyboards.

Naturally, the storyboards were hand-drawn. Acting in storyboards was naturally Director Dezaki's drawings. While somewhat resembling characters, they had the director's distinctive style. But the original art style and Kadono-san's (門之園) characters are like that. So there was a gap... (bitter laugh).

Girl characters I could mostly mentally convert, but the protagonist's friend Sunohara (春原) somehow... (bitter laugh). Our heads were completely imprinted with "Edo-dialect Sunohara (べらんめえ春原)" from Dezaki storyboards. "Hmm, this guy, you know..." Making character colour samples while inadvertently bitter laughing. Bridging the gap between "Dezaki World" and the original was quite difficult.

But I was dying to see how these guys would develop.

To be continued (laughs).

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